

The Lakes of Covadonga

Location The Picos de Europa, Asturias, Spain

The permeable limestone landscape of the high Picos de Europa massif in the Cantabrian Mountains is renowned for its amazing karst features, including gorges, caves, sinkholes—and a virtual absence of standing surface water. Two exceptions are Lakes Enol and Ercina, at an elevation of more than 3,600 ft (1,100 m), which retain water because of the presence of impermeable glacial deposits left behind after the last ice age.

The Tagus

Location The Sierra de Albarracín to Lisbon, Spain and Portugal

The longest river of the Iberian Peninsula (626 miles/1,007 km long) drains the second most expansive drainage basin (after that of the Ebro River). Rising in the Sierra de Albarracín, in eastern Spain, the Tagus flows through limestone ravines and gorges before reaching the vast semiarid plains of Castille. There it has been dammed in several places to provide water and hydroelectric power before it reaches the lowlands of Portugal, discharging into the Atlantic Ocean near Lisbon.

Doñana

Location Andalucía, Spain

This vast area at or close to sea level was given national park status for its rich tapestry of marshland, reedbeds, shallow streams, pools, and sand dunes—and the fauna that these habitats support, especially breeding and migrating birds. In the past, Doñana has been covered by both freshwater and saltwater, but it is now slowly drying out, mainly as a result of the extraction of water from its aquifer for agriculture. It is protected from inundation by a wide barrier of sand dunes.

Lake Constance

Location Western Austria, eastern Switzerland, and southern Germany

This freshwater body lies in a *zungenbecken*, or tongue basin, a long hollow scoured out and left behind by the Rhine Glacier as it retreated. The hollow filled with water and is now 39 miles (63 km) long and up to 827 ft (252 m) deep. The Rhine (see p.371) and other rivers are constantly depositing sediments in the lake, extending its coastline and reducing its depth.

▼ SHALLOW WATERS OF LAKE CONSTANCE

